ArchiMate cheat sheet — every element, by layer and aspect

All 60 elements of ArchiMate® 3.2 in one grid, placed by the two questions that decide where an element belongs.

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THE FRAMEWORK

layer answers **whom it serves** · aspect answers **what kind of thing it is**

	ACTIVE STRUCTURE who or what does it	BEHAVIOUR what is done	PASSIVE STRUCTURE what it is done to
Motivation why — its own aspect	Stakeholder · Driver · Assessment · Goal · Outcome · Principle · Requirement · Constraint · Meaning · Value		
Strategy what we must be able to do	Resource	Capability · Value Stream · Course of Action	—
Business what the organisation does for its customers	Business Actor · Business Role · Business Collaboration · Business Interface	Business Process · Business Function · Business Interaction · Business Event · Business Service	Business Object · Contract · Representation · **Product †**
Application what software does for the business	Application Component · Application Collaboration · Application Interface	Application Function · Application Interaction · Application Process · Application Event · Application Service	Data Object
Technology what infrastructure does for software	Node · Device · System Software · Technology Collaboration · Technology Interface · Path · Communication Network	Technology Function · Technology Process · Technology Interaction · Technology Event · Technology Service	Artifact
Physical part of Technology, not a layer of its own	Equipment · Facility · Distribution Network	*— uses Technology behaviour*	Material
Implementation & Migration how we get there	—	Work Package · Implementation Event	Deliverable · **Plateau ‡** · **Gap ‡**
Composite no layer of their own	Grouping — anything that belongs together · Location — where elements sit or behaviour happens		

† Product is composite, not passive structure: it aggregates services and passive elements across layers, under a contract. Most cheat sheets file it wrongly. **‡ Plateau** aggregates core elements as they stand at one point in time; **Gap** states the difference between two plateaus.

RELATIONSHIPS

11 + junction

STRUCTURAL — STATIC COHERENCE

- **Composition** — the part cannot exist without the whole
- **Aggregation** — groups parts that can exist alone
- **Assignment** — who performs it, where it runs
- **Realization** — the concrete one delivers the abstract one

DEPENDENCY — ONE NEEDS ANOTHER

- **Serving** — provides its functionality to another
- **Access** — reads, writes or deletes a passive element
- **Influence** (+/-) — affects a motivation element, for or against
- **Association** — a link the language has no word for

DYNAMIC — SOMETHING MOVES

- **Triggering** — this then that — order in time
- **Flow** — something is transferred — data, money, goods

OTHER & CONNECTOR

- **Specialization** — is a particular kind of
- **Junction** — and / or — joins relationships of one type

The derivation rule — the one worth memorising

A chain of relationships pointing the same way can be replaced by **the weakest link in the chain**. That is how a diagram stays readable when you zoom out.

`composition › aggregation › assignment › realization › serving › access › influence › association`

THREE PAIRS THAT GET CONFUSED

Assignment vs realization. Assignment allocates a performer — an actor *does* a process. Realization says something concrete delivers something abstract — a process *provides* a service.

Serving vs flow. Serving is a standing offer: it is available to you. Flow is one actual transfer during one run.

Composition vs aggregation. A composed part dies with its whole and has exactly one whole. An aggregated part survives on its own and may belong to several.

PLACING AN ELEMENT — TWO QUESTIONS

1. Whom does it serve? That is the layer. Technology serves applications, applications serve the business, the business serves its customers. **2. What kind of thing is it?** Active structure does something, behaviour is what is done, passive structure is what it is done to.

INTERNAL OR EXTERNAL — THE PAIR PEOPLE MISS

Every layer repeats the same pair. A **Service** is the outward face of **behaviour** — what others may use. An **Interface** is the outward face of **active structure** — where they reach it. Everything else in the layer is internal, and no one outside should depend on it.

READING THE NOTATION

Colour is convention, not specification — yellow business, blue application, green technology, purple motivation, tan strategy, pink implementation. Marks show the standard type icon or a distinctive element shape. A type icon sits in the **top-right** of its box; rounded boxes are behaviour, square boxes structure.

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Element set per the ArchiMate® 3.2 Specification. ArchiMate is a registered trademark of The Open Group.
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